MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 4: Drama (Non-detailed Study)

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

Kyd shows revenge growing from failed justice, while Jonson uses comedy to expose people trapped by jealousy, vanity, and mistaken beliefs.

Start with a picture

One story asks, “What happens when a grieving father cannot obtain justice?” The other asks, “What happens when people believe every foolish suspicion in their heads?” Both plays connect individual behaviour with social order, but their emotional effects differ.

1. Thomas Kyd: The Spanish Tragedy

Meet the main figures

- **Don Andrea:** a dead Spanish soldier whose ghost watches events.
- **Revenge:** a personified force accompanying the ghost.
- **Bel-Imperia:** Andrea’s former beloved, later in love with Horatio.
- **Horatio:** son of Hieronimo and Isabella.
- **Hieronimo:** a royal judicial officer and grieving father.
- **Lorenzo:** Bel-Imperia’s brother, who helps plan Horatio’s murder.
- **Balthazar:** a Portuguese prince interested in Bel-Imperia.

Follow the main events

Andrea has died in war. His ghost and Revenge observe the unfolding action. Bel-Imperia turns towards Horatio, but Lorenzo and Balthazar arrange Horatio’s murder. Hieronimo discovers his son’s body and seeks an explanation and justice.

Powerful people obstruct the search. Bel-Imperia’s message helps expose responsibility. Hieronimo eventually organises a court entertainment, a **play within the play**, which becomes the means of actual killing. Revenge produces further deaths, including those of the revengers themselves.

What is the play asking?

Justice versus revenge: the law should protect people, but unequal power prevents it from doing so. Hieronimo's suffering makes his anger understandable without making every action morally simple.

Grief: revenge begins in an intimate loss, not merely in a wish for excitement.

Theatre and reality: a staged performance becomes real violence. The audience must think about the power and danger of representation.

Fate: the ghost and Revenge frame events within forces beyond the human characters' full control.

2. Ben Jonson: Every Man in His Humour

What does "humour" mean?

It means a dominant disposition associated with an old theory of bodily fluids. A person can be so governed by one tendency that it distorts ordinary judgement.

Imagine wearing jealous spectacles: even an innocent conversation begins to look suspicious. The spectacles represent the controlling humour.

Follow the main situation

In the English version used in this unit, Knowell worries about his son Edward's companions and interests. Brainworm uses disguises and deception. Kitely is excessively jealous about his wife. Stephen and Matthew want to appear fashionable or accomplished, while Bobadill boasts of military courage.

Misunderstandings multiply because people trust their own vanity or fear. Edward and Bridget's relationship develops amid these confusions. Justice Clement helps expose errors and restore order.

What should you notice?

- **Kitely:** jealousy makes him misread situations.
- **Bobadill:** boasting and actual courage do not match.
- **Stephen and Matthew:** pretension replaces genuine understanding.
- **Brainworm:** disguise and trickery move the plot.
- **Knowell:** parental anxiety becomes an object of examination.

Jonson's satire encourages an audience to recognise social follies in familiar life.

Compare the plays

Question	The Spanish Tragedy	Every Man in His Humour
Main pressure	Murder and blocked justice	Distorted judgement and pretension
Emotional movement	Grief towards destructive revenge	Confusion towards exposure
Major device	Ghost and play within a play	Disguise and comic misunderstanding
Social question	Can power prevent justice?	Can people recognise their own folly?

Build an exam answer

For revenge tragedy, connect the ghost, murder, failed justice, delay, and final performance. For comedy of humours, explain the concept and then show how two characters act under a dominant disposition.

Quick check

1. Who is Horatio’s father? **Hieronimo.**
2. What turns performance into a weapon? **The final play within the play.**
3. Is a “humour” simply a joke? **No; it is a governing disposition.**

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

Compare the social criticism in The Spanish Tragedy and Every Man in His Humour.

Expanded discussion

Kyd’s tragedy presents revenge within a world where official justice is obstructed by unequal power. Hieronimo’s position makes this especially disturbing: he has a public connection with law, yet cannot secure justice for his murdered son. His grief therefore becomes a means of examining institutional failure. The audience can understand the pressure towards revenge while remaining troubled by the further violence it produces.

The ghost and the personification of Revenge place the human action within a larger theatrical frame. Meanwhile, the final play within the play turns representation into an instrument of killing. This device does more than provide surprise. It connects theatre with hidden intention, political power, and the difficulty of distinguishing appearance from reality. The protagonist becomes a maker of the performance through which his enemies are destroyed.

Jonson directs criticism towards familiar social habits rather than an escalating chain of revenge. Kitely’s jealousy, Bobadill’s boasting, and the pretensions of Stephen and Matthew expose judgement distorted by a governing disposition. Disguise and misunderstanding

reveal how easily people accept what their own anxiety or vanity prepares them to believe. Justice Clement’s role contrasts with the obstructed justice of Kyd’s world by helping to bring errors into the open.

Both plays reveal a gap between social appearance and reality. Their outcomes differ: Kyd intensifies suffering and destruction, whereas Jonson’s comic exposure permits a greater movement towards correction. A comparison should therefore consider dramatic method and audience response, not simply list one play as sad and the other as funny.

Suggested answer structure

1. Define the social problem in each play
2. Hieronimo and failed justice
3. Ghost and final performance
4. Humours and comic self-deception
5. Contrast destruction with correction

Common mistakes to avoid

Keep Horatio and Hieronimo distinct. Explain “humour” historically rather than using it as a synonym for a joke.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.